Say This



The words for every screen moment

Fifty cards, one for each of the hard screen and tech moments of a childhood, from the first tablet to the last rule. The moment is on the front, in your child's words or as it happens. The words to say are on the back, with one line on why they work. None of them is a yes or a no. Every card is a next step you can take tonight.

PRINT

Pages 2 to 31 are the cards. Print them double sided and choose **flip on long edge**. Card or thick paper, 200 to 300gsm, feels like a real deck. Try pages 2 and 3 first to check the backs line up.

NO DUPLEX?

Print every page single sided. Cut out each front and its back, then glue them together back to back. Page 3 is the back of page 2, page 5 the back of page 4, and so on.

CUT

Cut along the dashed lines. The colour runs a little past each line, so a small wobble never shows. Round the corners with scissors if you like.

Five levels, one for each stage

Start at your child's age. Read the level before it too: the moments do not wait for birthdays.

	LEVEL 1 **Pebble**	**4 to 7**	First screens, first rules, and the big feelings when the screen goes off.	CARDS 1 TO 10
	LEVEL 2 **Bloop**	**8 to 10**	Gaming, group chats, the bedroom and the first phone ask, before the habits set.	CARDS 11 TO 20
	LEVEL 3 **Orbit**	**11 to 12**	The first phone, the feed, the class group at night, and what AI actually is.	CARDS 21 TO 30
	LEVEL 4 **Nova**	**13 to 15**	When things go wrong online, and keeping the door open while you still can.	CARDS 31 TO 40
	LEVEL 5 **Cosmo**	**16 and up**	Asking rather than telling, as the phone and the choices become theirs.	CARDS 41 TO 50

60 cards in all: a cover, how to use, five level cards, the fifty moments, a card about the app and two blank cards for a moment of your own.

GUIDED CHILDHOOD · SCRIPT CARDS



Say This

The words for every screen moment

50 SCRIPTS · AGES 4 TO 16



Guided Childhood

BEFORE THE FIRST CARD

How to use these cards

1. **Find the moment**
   Go to your child's level, then the moment on the front that sounds like your house.
2. **Read it before you need it**
   The words land best practised at the kettle, not found in the middle of a meltdown.
3. **Say it your way**
   Keep the meaning, change the words until they sound like you.
4. **Then the next step**
   No card is a yes or a no. Each one is where to go next.

LEVEL 1 OF 5

FOUNDATION



Pebble

Ages 4 to 7

First screens, first rules, and the big feelings when the screen goes off.

01 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

THE FIRST SCREEN

Screens are new, and there is no rule yet.

The First Device Conversation. The talk on the Pebble page of the Passport.



SAY THIS

WHEN A MOMENT IS NOT HERE

Two blank cards are at the back

Write your own moment on the front and the words that work in your house on the back. Your family knows things no deck can.

THE APP

These are 50 of the scripts in the Guided Childhood app. The app holds every one of them, over 300, plus the lessons and the stage check.

WHAT IS IN THE DECK

Fifty moments, five levels

Pebble	4 to 7	1 TO 10
Bloop	8 to 10	11 TO 20
Orbit	11 to 12	21 TO 30
Nova	13 to 15	31 TO 40
Cosmo	16 and up	41 TO 50

The first card of every level is the talk on that stage's page of the Guided Childhood Passport.

01 · THE FIRST SCREEN PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> We have a family rule about screens. When the timer goes off, screens go down. Every time, no exceptions. And then we do something together.

WHY IT WORKS

Children at this stage cannot regulate device use themselves.

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

The moments in this level

01 Screens are new, and there is no rule yet.
02 I am not finished!
03 Not yet! Two more minutes!
04 Why can I not have my own phone?
05 But all my friends play it!
06 Just one more show before bed.
07 I am bored. There is nothing to do.
08 It is MY turn!
09 Who is that talking in my game?
10 You shouted. They are quiet now.

02 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

THE TIMER GOES

“I am not finished!”

They cry, argue or melt down as the TV or tablet goes off.



SAY THIS

03 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

THE TIMER GOES

“Not yet! Two more minutes!”

You give the warning, you count down, and the ending still ends in tears.



SAY THIS

04 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

THE PHONE ASK

“Why can I not have my own phone?”

Your 5, 6 or 7 year old asks why they cannot have one like their friend.



SAY THIS

05 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT

“But all my friends play it!”

They ask, for the first time, to play a game because all of their friends are playing it.



SAY THIS

03 · THE TIMER GOES PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> When this episode finishes, the tablet finishes too. Not me, the tablet. Let us watch the last bit together and see the end come. Then it is your turn to press the button.

WHY IT WORKS

The countdown feels like fairness, and for a four year old it is a slow burning threat with a parent attached to it.

02 · THE TIMER GOES PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> I know that feels really hard. Your brain wants to keep going. That is normal. Let us do a quick wind down together and then I will tell you when we can watch again.

WHY IT WORKS

The meltdown is a nervous system response, not a behaviour problem.

05 · EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> I can tell this one really matters because your friends love it. Let me have a proper look at it first, and then we will decide together if it is right for you.

WHY IT WORKS

Wanting to belong is one of the strongest drives at this age, so this request is about friendship as much as the game.

04 · THE PHONE ASK PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> Your brain is still growing the part that helps you put the phone down. When that part is stronger you will be ready. Right now we share mine when we need it.

WHY IT WORKS

Explaining the biology rather than asserting authority keeps the conversation open.

06 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

BEDTIME

“Just one more show before bed.”

A screen in the hour before bed has become part of their wind down.



SAY THIS

07 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

AFTER THE SCREEN

“I am bored. There is nothing to do.”

The device is away, and nothing suggested is good enough.



SAY THIS

08 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

SHARING

“It is MY turn!”

Two children, one tablet, and the volume is climbing.



SAY THIS

09 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

STRANGERS ONLINE

“Who is that talking in my game?”

Your young child is starting to play games or use apps online.



SAY THIS

07 · AFTER THE SCREEN — PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> I hear you. Bored is uncomfortable. Give it ten minutes and see what your brain comes up with.

WHY IT WORKS

The uncomfortable gap is real, not performed.

LEVEL 1 · AGES 4 TO 7 — GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

06 · BEDTIME — PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> Screens are done for the night now. Your brain needs time to slow down before sleep, and screens make that harder. Let's do something calmer together.

WHY IT WORKS

Framing it as brain science rather than a rule removes the battle of wills.

LEVEL 1 · AGES 4 TO 7 — GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

09 · STRANGERS ONLINE — PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> You know how we have a rule about strangers in real life? We have the same rule online. Someone online you have never met in real life is a stranger, even if they seem friendly. You always come and tell me if someone you don't know tries to talk to you.

WHY IT WORKS

The most important outcome is a child who comes to a trusted adult rather than handling something confusing or worrying alone.

LEVEL 1 · AGES 4 TO 7 — GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

08 · SHARING — PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> Stop, both of you. The tablet sits on the side while we sort this out. It is one turn each, ten minutes, and the timer decides when, not the loudest voice. Who was mid turn? Then that turn finishes first.

WHY IT WORKS

A visible timer moves the battle from you against them to everyone against the clock.

LEVEL 1 · AGES 4 TO 7 — GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

10 / 50

LEVEL 1 · PEBBLE · 4 TO 7

REPAIR

You shouted. They are quiet now.

And you feel sick about it.



SAY THIS

LEVEL 2 OF 5

BUILDER



Bloop

Ages 8 to 10

Gaming, group chats, the bedroom and the first phone ask, before the habits set.

11 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

THE BEDROOM

“Can my phone sleep in my room?”

The Bedroom Rule. The talk on the Bloop page of the Passport.



SAY THIS

12 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

THE TIMER GOES

“I cannot stop now, I am mid match!”

They are mid game, other children are relying on them, and leaving now costs them something real.



SAY THIS

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

The moments in this level

11 Can my phone sleep in my room?

12 I cannot stop now, I am mid match!

13 It is so unfair! I always lose!

14 Everyone is in the group chat but me.

15 Am I getting a phone for secondary school?

16 Can I watch YouTube in my room?

17 I play with someone online. They are really good.

18 Can I buy this skin? It is only 800 coins.

19 Nothing. I am fine.

20 The tablet was on under the covers again.

10 · REPAIR PEBBLE

SAY THIS

> I shouted and that was not okay. It was not your fault. I am working on it. I love you.

WHY IT WORKS

No parent avoids the rupture and every parent can do the repair.

12 · THE TIMER GOES BLOOP

SAY THIS

> I know you cannot just walk out of a match, that is not me not listening. So here is what we are going to do from now on. Before you start, we agree how many matches, and you stop at the end of the last one, never in the middle. For this one, tell me how long it has left, and I will hold you to it.

WHY IT WORKS

In a team game, leaving mid match takes the other players down with you.

11 · THE BEDROOM BLOOP

SAY THIS

> Where does your phone sleep at night? In our house, phones sleep in the kitchen. The bedroom is for sleep. That is our rule and it will not change.

WHY IT WORKS

Set it now, before they have a personal device, and it is just how things work.

13 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

GAMING

“It is so unfair! I always lose!”

They have just thrown a controller, burst into tears, or shouted after losing a game.



SAY THIS

14 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT

“Everyone is in the group chat but me.”

Your 8, 9 or 10 year old asks to join a messaging app or game chat because their friends are on it.



SAY THIS

15 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

THE PHONE ASK

“Am I getting a phone for secondary school?”

Year 6 has started, and the phone question is in the air.



SAY THIS

16 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

ALONE WITH A SCREEN

“Can I watch YouTube in my room?”

They want to watch YouTube in their room on their own.



SAY THIS

14 · EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT

BLOOP

SAY THIS

> I want you to be connected with your friends. Let us look at this together and work out whether it is designed for your age and what the rules would be if you joined.

WHY IT WORKS

Blanket refusal at this stage pushes the conversation underground.

13 · GAMING

BLOOP

SAY THIS

> That was really frustrating. Take a minute. I am going to get you a drink.

WHY IT WORKS

The emotion is real even when the trigger seems small.

16 · ALONE WITH A SCREEN

BLOOP

SAY THIS

> YouTube is built to keep you watching. That is not your fault, it is how it works. For now, can we keep it in the living room so I can see what comes up? When you are older and we both feel confident about it, we can talk about moving it.

WHY IT WORKS

The child hears "I trust you, I do not trust the algorithm."

15 · THE PHONE ASK

BLOOP

SAY THIS

> You are probably getting a phone before secondary school, and I want us to plan it together now rather than fight about it in October. So let us decide three things while it is easy. Where it sleeps at night, which is not your bedroom. What it is for to start with. And a promise from me: if you ever show me something bad on it, the phone stays yours. Telling me never costs you the phone.

WHY IT WORKS

Every decision is easier before the box is opened.

17 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

STRANGERS ONLINE

“I play with someone online. They are really good.”

They have been playing with people they do not know in real life, and chatting during the game.



SAY THIS

18 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

MONEY IN GAMES

“Can I buy this skin? It is only 800 coins.”

They are asking to buy in game items and do not fully understand that real money is involved.



SAY THIS

19 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

GROUP CHATS

“Nothing. I am fine.”

They came home quiet, and something happened in the class group chat.



SAY THIS

20 / 50

LEVEL 2 · BLOOP · 8 TO 10

SNEAKING

The tablet was on under the covers again.

Getting up early, using a device after lights out, or hiding what they are doing.



SAY THIS

18 · MONEY IN GAMES BLOOP

SAY THIS

> Let me show you what that actually costs in real money. That skin costs the same as a trip to the cinema for both of us. I'm not saying never, but I want you to understand what you're asking for before we decide.

WHY IT WORKS

Children often genuinely do not connect digital currency to real world money.

LEVEL 2 · AGES 8 TO 10 GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

17 · STRANGERS ONLINE BLOOP

SAY THIS

> Who are you playing with? Tell me about them. I'm not going to stop you playing, but I want to make sure you know the rules about what's safe to share with people you only know online.

WHY IT WORKS

Teaching the specific rules around what to share and what to keep private is more durable and more honest.

LEVEL 2 · AGES 8 TO 10 GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

20 · SNEAKING BLOOP

SAY THIS

> I found out you had the screen on when you were not supposed to. I'm not going to shout, but I do want to understand why. Can you tell me what was going on?

WHY IT WORKS

Sneaking usually means the child feels the limit is either unfair or unachievable.

LEVEL 2 · AGES 8 TO 10 GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

19 · GROUP CHATS BLOOP

SAY THIS

> Something happened in the group chat, didn't it. You don't have to tell me what. But I am here if you do.

WHY IT WORKS

Naming what you can see and leaving the door open gets you more than demanding to see the evidence.

LEVEL 2 · AGES 8 TO 10 GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

LEVEL 3 OF 5

EXPLORER



Orbit

Ages 11 to 12

The first phone, the feed, the class group at night, and what AI actually is.

21 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

THE FEED

“Why does it keep showing me this stuff?”

The Algorithm Conversation. The talk on the Orbit page of the Passport.



SAY THIS

22 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

THE TIMER GOES

“Five more minutes. Please.”

Bedtime has already been extended twice.



SAY THIS

23 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

THE FIRST PHONE

“If I tell you, will you take my phone?”

You want them to tell you when something goes wrong on it, and you fear they will not.



SAY THIS

21 · THE FEED ORBIT

SAY THIS

> Did you know your phone is learning what you like? Every video you watch, every post you pause on, it notes it. Let me show you something. Open your feed and we will look at it together.

WHY IT WORKS

The parent who can talk about this without alarm is the greatest protective factor.

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

The moments in this level

21 Why does it keep showing me this stuff?
22 Five more minutes. Please.
23 If I tell you, will you take my phone?
24 Everyone else is allowed!
25 I cannot mute it. I will miss everything.
26 They took me out of the group.
27 Someone keeps being horrible to me online.
28 Off the phone, upset, and not saying why.
29 It was only a few pounds.
30 What actually is AI?

23 · THE FIRST PHONE ORBIT

SAY THIS

> I need you to hear this properly. If you ever see something on your phone that scares you, or someone sends you something horrible, or you get into something you cannot get out of, you come and show me, and the phone stays yours. I will not take it off you for telling me. Telling me is the thing that keeps it.

WHY IT WORKS

Children go quiet when telling costs them the phone.

22 · THE TIMER GOES ORBIT

SAY THIS

> I know. And we are done now. Device off. I will come in to say goodnight.

WHY IT WORKS

The five more minutes negotiation reflects genuine disappointment, not defiance.

24 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT

“Everyone else is allowed!”

Their friends are allowed far more than they are.



SAY THIS

25 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

GROUP CHATS

“I cannot mute it. I will miss everything.”

The class group is going off late into the night and they cannot leave it alone.



SAY THIS

26 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

LEFT OUT

“They took me out of the group.”

They have been removed from a group chat, and it is being done to hurt them.



SAY THIS

27 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

SOMETHING WENT WRONG

“Someone keeps being horrible to me online.”

Someone is being cruel to them in messages, comments or posts.



SAY THIS

25 · GROUP CHATS ORBIT

SAY THIS

> That group does not stop, and I do not think you can be the one who stops it. So let us take you out of the room instead of you out of the group. What actually happens if you mute it until the morning?

WHY IT WORKS

Muting until morning rather than leaving keeps the standing and drops the vigilance.

24 · EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT ORBIT

SAY THIS

> I believe you that your friends have different rules, and that does feel unfair. Every family decides what works for them, and I am happy to explain the why behind ours.

WHY IT WORKS

Acknowledging the unfair feeling while standing by your why teaches them rules can have reasons, not just power.

27 · SOMETHING WENT WRONG ORBIT

SAY THIS

> I am really glad you told me. That sounds genuinely awful, and it makes complete sense that you are upset. Can you show me what has been happening so I understand the full picture?

WHY IT WORKS

Starting with validation before solutions tells your child their feelings are the priority, not the fix.

26 · LEFT OUT ORBIT

SAY THIS

> Being taken out of that group was meant to hurt and it did. I am not going to tell you it does not matter. Removing someone is one of the easiest cruel things there is, which is exactly why people do it. Who did it, and are they doing it to anyone else?

WHY IT WORKS

Telling them to leave asks the child being hurt to do the withdrawing.

28 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

FEELINGS

Off the phone, upset, and not saying why.

Irritable, withdrawn or tearful, and they will not talk about what they saw.



SAY THIS

29 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

MONEY IN GAMES

“It was only a few pounds.”

Money has gone out on skins, coins, a battle pass or a loot box.



SAY THIS

30 / 50

LEVEL 3 · ORBIT · 11 TO 12

AI

“What actually is AI?”

They ask what AI is and how it works.



SAY THIS

LEVEL 4 OF 5

SHAPER



Nova

Ages 13 to 15

When things go wrong online, and keeping the door open while you still can.

29 · MONEY IN GAMES ORBIT

SAY THIS

> I am not cross, and I want to understand it before we sort it. Show me what you bought and what it does. Then show me what it cost, because I think the game made that quite hard to see, and I want to know whether you knew.

WHY IT WORKS

Start with what it does rather than what it cost, and you will find out whether this was a decision or a design.

28 · FEELINGS ORBIT

SAY THIS

> You seem like something got to you. I am not going to ask you to tell me what it was. But if something is sitting with you and you want to talk later, I am here. That is it.

WHY IT WORKS

Interrogating the child immediately after an emotional response to content closes the door.

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

The moments in this level

31 Before anything goes wrong online.
32 I was only on it for a bit.
33 I am not a little kid anymore!
34 Nobody else has rules like this.
35 You are tempted to look through their phone.
36 Someone has a photo of me. They want money.
37 Someone sent something horrible to the group.
38 Have you seen what they wrote under my post?
39 It actually listens to me.
40 Always on the phone, barely there.

30 · AI ORBIT

SAY THIS

> Think of it as a very clever guesser. It has read a huge amount of writing and learned to predict what words usually come next, so it sounds sure even when it is wrong.

WHY IT WORKS

Knowing it guesses helps them treat its answers as a starting point, not the final word.

31 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

SOMETHING WENT WRONG

Before anything goes wrong online.

When Things Go Wrong Online. The talk on the Nova page of the Passport.



SAY THIS

32 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

SLEEP

“I was only on it for a bit.”

They are on their phone after lights out, often until 1 or 2am.



SAY THIS

33 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

THE RULES

“I am not a little kid anymore!”

They argue the rules are unfair and that they are being treated like a child.



SAY THIS

34 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT

“Nobody else has rules like this.”

They say theirs is the only strict house, and the rules are making them an outcast.



SAY THIS

32 · SLEEP NOVA

SAY THIS

> I found out you were on your phone late. I am not angry. I am worried about your sleep because of what I know about how it affects your mood and your brain. I want to sort this together rather than take the phone.

WHY IT WORKS

Punishing the symptom with phone removal for a week does not address the underlying drive.

31 · SOMETHING WENT WRONG NOVA

SAY THIS

> If anything ever goes wrong online, and things do go wrong, I am the first call you make, not the last. I will not overreact. I will help.

WHY IT WORKS

A child who fears losing their phone is a child who hides problems.

34 · EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT NOVA

SAY THIS

> I hear you, and I'm not going to pretend your friends all have the same limits we have. I also can't parent based on what every other family does. What I can do is explain why I've made the choices I have, and I'm genuinely open to hearing what feels unfair to you.

WHY IT WORKS

Explaining your reasoning treats them as someone capable of understanding, which is what teenagers want.

33 · THE RULES NOVA

SAY THIS

> You're right that you're not a small kid anymore, and I do want to give you more control. Let's talk about what you think is reasonable and why, and we can work out something together.

WHY IT WORKS

Adolescence is the developmental stage where young people are supposed to be pushing for autonomy.

35 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

TRUST

You are tempted to look through their phone.

Without asking them first.



SAY THIS

36 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

IMAGES

“Someone has a photo of me. They want money.”

They sent an image to someone they believed was their age, and that account is now threatening them.



SAY THIS

37 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

GROUP CHATS

“Someone sent something horrible to the group.”

A violent, sexual or disturbing image or video has been forwarded into a group chat they are in.



SAY THIS

38 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

FEELINGS

“Have you seen what they wrote under my post?”

Something they posted attracts a wave of negative comments.



SAY THIS

36 · IMAGES NOVA

SAY THIS

> Thank you for telling me. I need you to hear the next bit before anything else: you are not in trouble, and this is not your fault. This is a crime, it is done to thousands of people, and the people doing it are organised criminals who do this for money. We are not paying them. We are not deleting anything yet, because the messages are evidence. I am going to sit here with you while we block them and report it, and then we will get the picture taken down.

WHY IT WORKS

Shame is the whole weapon.

Report Remove, run by Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation, takes reports from under 18s.

35 · TRUST NOVA

SAY THIS

> If I am ever worried enough to look at your phone, I will tell you and we will look together. I would rather you trust me than feel watched behind your back.

WHY IT WORKS

Secret searches, once found, end the openness you actually need to keep them safe.

38 · FEELINGS NOVA

SAY THIS

> That stings and I am sorry it happened. You do not have to read every comment, and a stranger having a bad day does not get to decide how you feel about yourself.

WHY IT WORKS

Blame in a raw moment teaches them to hide the next hit instead of bringing it to you.

37 · GROUP CHATS NOVA

SAY THIS

> Do not forward it and do not delete it yet. You are not in trouble for being sent it, being sent something is not the same as sharing it. Tell me what it was, roughly, and then we will decide together what happens next.

WHY IT WORKS

Separating being sent something from sharing it is the sentence that keeps a teenager honest with you.

39 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

AI

“It actually listens to me.”

They are talking to an AI chatbot as though it is a close friend.



SAY THIS

40 / 50

LEVEL 4 · NOVA · 13 TO 15

FAMILY TIME

Always on the phone, barely there.

They barely respond when spoken to, and seem more present online than at home.



SAY THIS

LEVEL 5 OF 5

INDEPENDENT



Cosmo

Ages 16 and up

Asking rather than telling, as the phone and the choices become theirs.

41 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

INDEPENDENCE

“It is my phone. It is my life.”

Building Independence. The talk on the Cosmo page of the Passport.



SAY THIS

40 · FAMILY TIME NOVA

SAY THIS

> I feel like I'm losing you to your phone and I miss you. I'm not trying to control what you do, I just want some time where we're actually together. Can we figure out something that works for both of us?

WHY IT WORKS

Naming the feeling of missing them rather than attacking the behaviour shifts the conversation from a power struggle to a relationship conversation.

39 · AI NOVA

SAY THIS

> It makes sense that it feels good to talk to, it never gets tired or judges you. I just want you to remember it cannot actually care back, even when it sounds like it does.

WHY IT WORKS

Honouring why it appeals, while naming the limit, keeps real human connection as the goal without shaming them.

41 · INDEPENDENCE COSMO

SAY THIS

> You are at the age where you get to decide what kind of digital life you build. What does your online presence say about who you are? Not to me. To the world.

WHY IT WORKS

At 16, the goal is not compliance but genuine digital literacy.

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

The moments in this level

41 It is my phone. It is my life.
42 Sixteen, and the rules have run out.
43 2am, and the light is still on.
44 You need a real talk. They are half scrolling.
45 They tell their phone everything. You, nothing.
46 My feed just shows me what is out there.
47 I cannot stop scrolling the news.
48 It is just a free bet on the football.
49 Old enough to date, and to share.
50 Will AI even leave me a job?

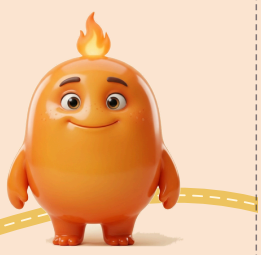
42 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

THE RULES

Sixteen, and the rules have run out.

You can see the phone costing them sleep, coursework or mood, and you have no lever left.



SAY THIS

43 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

SLEEP

2am, and the light is still on.

You get up in the night and your 16 or 17 year old is still awake on their phone.



SAY THIS

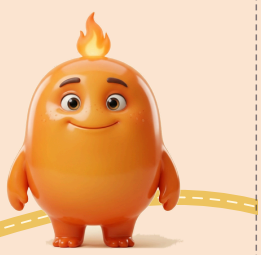
44 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

TALKING

You need a real talk. They are half scrolling.

A real conversation is needed, and they are only half present.



SAY THIS

45 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

TALKING

They tell their phone everything. You, nothing.

You find out what is happening in their life through glimpses rather than from them.



SAY THIS

43 · SLEEP COSMO

SAY THIS

> Nothing tonight. Tomorrow: I saw you were up late last night. I am not checking on you but I am a bit worried. What is going on?

WHY IT WORKS

At 16 and 17, surveillance without conversation produces secrecy, not change.

42 · THE RULES COSMO

SAY THIS

> You are sixteen, so this is yours now and I am not going to pretend otherwise. That means I am asking rather than telling. Is your phone working for you at the moment, honestly? Because from out here it looks like it is winning, and if you think so too I will help with whatever you want to try. If you think I am wrong, tell me and I will drop it.

WHY IT WORKS

At sixteen the lever really has gone, and pretending otherwise costs you the only thing you have left, which is being someone they will talk to.

45 · TALKING COSMO

SAY THIS

> I know you have your own life and I am not trying to get in the way of it. I just want to know how you are. Not the detail. Just you.

WHY IT WORKS

It asks for mood, not detail.

44 · TALKING COSMO

SAY THIS

> I want to talk to you properly for ten minutes. Can we both put our phones face down? I will go first.

WHY IT WORKS

When the parent puts their own phone away first, the request shifts from instruction to invitation.

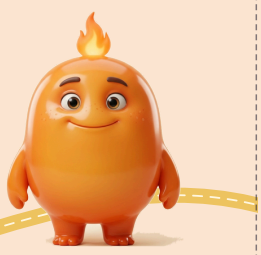
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LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

THE FEED

“My feed just shows me what is out there.”

They may be mistaking what the algorithm picks for a balanced view of the world.



SAY THIS

47 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

DOOMSCROLLING

“I cannot stop scrolling the news.”

Scrolling upsetting content late at night, and they cannot seem to stop.



SAY THIS

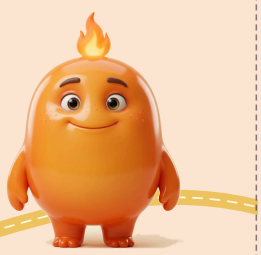
48 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

GAMBLING

“It is just a free bet on the football.”

Betting apps are heavily marketed to young men especially.



SAY THIS

49 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

IMAGES

Old enough to date, and to share.

They need to understand consent and the law around intimate images.



SAY THIS

47 · DOOMSCROLLING COSMO

SAY THIS

> There is a name for what you are describing and it is doomscrolling, and it happens to almost everyone. Your brain is wired to scan for threats, and the algorithm knows that, so it feeds you more of what got your attention. The loop is not your fault and you can interrupt it.

WHY IT WORKS

Naming doomscrolling as a recognised pattern removes the sense of being uniquely weak or broken.

46 · THE FEED COSMO

SAY THIS

> Do you know how much of what you see on your feeds is actively chosen for you based on keeping you watching? I find it genuinely unsettling when I think about it. What do you reckon your algorithm thinks you want to see?

WHY IT WORKS

The question about what the algorithm thinks they want to see invites your young adult to look at their own feed with fresh eyes.

49 · IMAGES COSMO

SAY THIS

> You are an adult or nearly one, so I will speak to you straight. Sharing an intimate image of someone without their consent is not just unkind, it is against the law, and so is pressuring someone to send one. The principle underneath all of it is consent. Are you clear on where those lines are?

WHY IT WORKS

Grounding the conversation in consent gives them a principle that covers situations a rule cannot anticipate.

48 · GAMBLING COSMO

SAY THIS

> Betting apps are everywhere now, dressed up as a bit of fun with the football. Here is what they do not advertise: they are engineered so the house wins over time, and they are very good at getting young people hooked. You are sharp enough to see the design. What do you reckon the free bet is actually buying them?

WHY IT WORKS

Understanding the design protects far longer than a slogan they will tune out.

50 / 50

LEVEL 5 · COSMO · 16 AND UP

AI

“Will AI even leave me a job?”

They wonder what AI means for their studies and career.



SAY THIS

WHEN YOU NEED THE NEXT ONE



50 here. Over 300 in the app.

A / yours

OUR FAMILY

OUR MOMENT



SAY THIS

B / yours

OUR FAMILY

OUR MOMENT



SAY THIS

THE GUIDED CHILDHOOD APP

The deck is a start. The app is the whole road to 16.

- **Every script**
  Over 300 moments, for every age from 4 to 16.
- **The lessons**
  Ten minutes a day, parent and child together.
- **The stage check**
  Three questions that show where your child is now.

50 · AI COSMO

SAY THIS

> AI will change a lot of jobs, and that is genuinely uncertain. The people who do well will be the ones who stay curious, keep thinking for themselves, and use it as a tool rather than a crutch.

WHY IT WORKS

Naming the uncertainty while pointing to durable human strengths gives them something hopeful and active to do with it.

B · OUR MOMENT

SAY THIS

WHY IT WORKS FOR US

A · OUR MOMENT

SAY THIS

WHY IT WORKS FOR US

THE GUIDED CHILDHOOD PASSPORT

Your Passport stickers

Say This belongs on every stage page, under the talk, from Pebble (ages 4 to 7) to Cosmo (16 and up), in the Guided Childhood Passport. When your family has used a level, tick Say This in the Go further strip on that stage page, then cut out its sticker and stick it on. The big one fits the stage page and the small one fits the fold out passport.



PRINT THIS PAGE ON STICKER PAPER, OR ON PLAIN PAPER WITH A GLUE STICK

The Guided Childhood app holds every script, over 300 of them, plus the lessons and the stage check, so the next hard moment already has its words.

No Passport yet? Look for the Guided Childhood Passport in the same Etsy shop: five stage pages for ages 4 to 16, each one stamped when the talk, the doing and the check are done.



A FREE GIFT FOR YOUR FAMILY

As a thank you, the full Guided Childhood Starter Pack is yours free: the star chart, the jobs that earn the stars, and a whole booklet of things to do away from a screen. Pop your email in at the address below and it is yours.

guidedchildhood.com/etsy-bonus

Made by Justin at Guided Childhood, a dad who got tired of the screen time fight. If the cards helped, a review on Etsy helps another parent find them.